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AFGHANISTAN

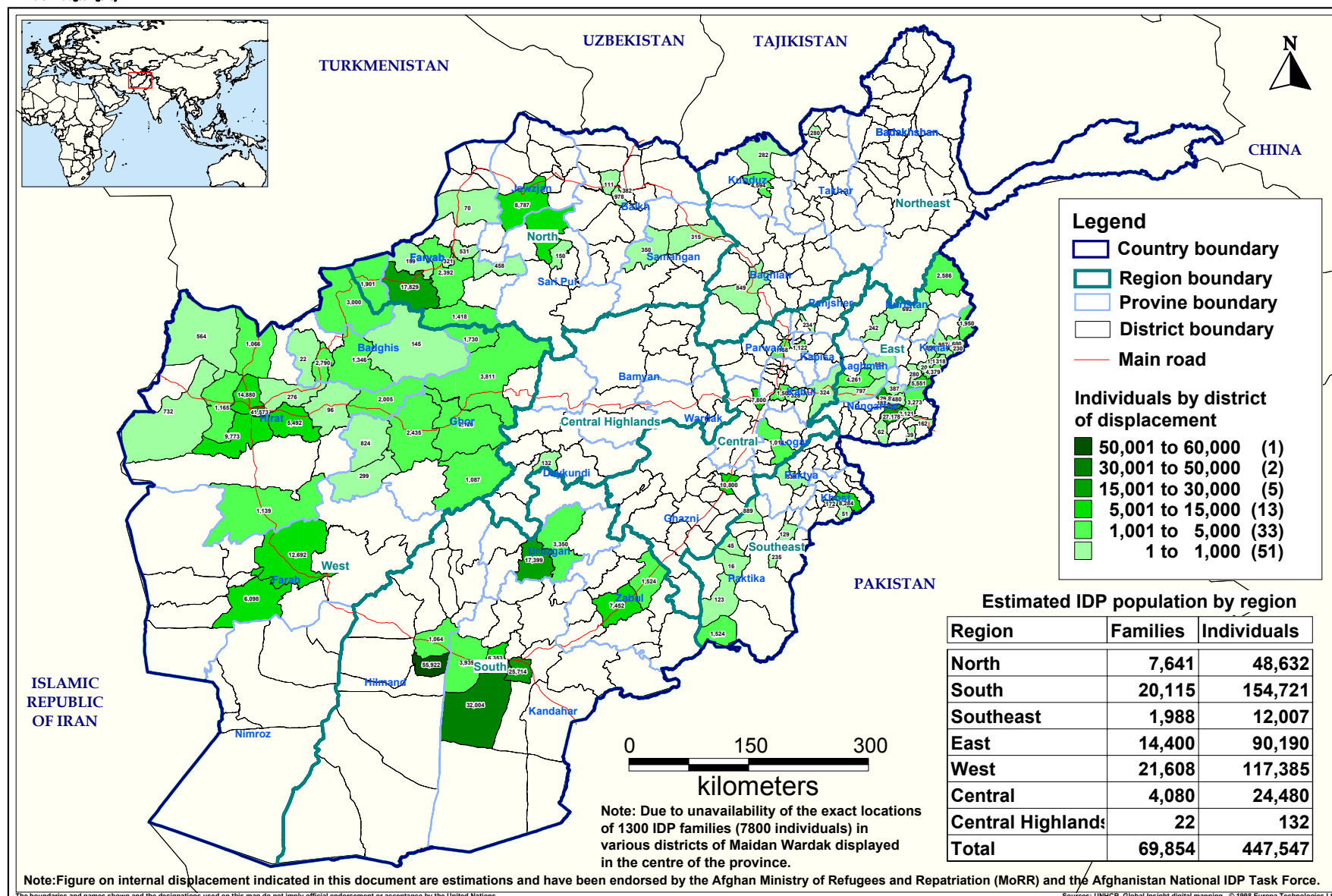
Durable solutions far from reach amid escalating conflict

More than ten years after the fall of the Taliban, Afghanistan's transition towards peace and stability remains far from complete. Decades of armed conflict, natural disasters and extreme weather have had a devastating effect on Afghan society, causing significant civilian casualties, widespread destruction of property and infrastructure and numerous waves of displacement. Some 75 per cent of Afghans are thought to have experienced some form of displacement at least once during their lives, and the escalation and spread of armed conflict in recent years has led to a renewed rise in the number of internally displaced people (IDPs). Armed conflict and violence continue to disrupt the lives of Afghans today; an average of 400 Afghans a day have fled their homes since 2006, bringing the current number of IDPs to well over 500,000.

IDPs are among the people most at risk in society and the vast majority are beyond the reach of humanitarian organisations. They are often exposed to human rights abuses and food insecurity, and their return to their places of origin is hampered by a lack of protection, livelihood opportunities and essential services. Many have been forced into prolonged secondary and even tertiary displacement. Significant numbers seek relative security in urban areas, where they are indistinguishable from the masses of urban poor, but at the same time more vulnerable as they are particularly affected by unemployment, limited access to adequate housing, and food insecurity.

There is an urgent need for both the Afghan Government and the international community to prioritise the protection and assistance of IDPs, and to dedicate humanitarian and development resources to the task within the framework of a comprehensive strategy on displacement. Such a strategy must cover the full range of durable solutions, with particular attention paid to the local integration of urban IDPs. Recent indications of the government's intention to develop a national IDP policy are welcome, but these should be accompanied by a strengthened coordinating role for the Ministry of Refugees and Repatriation (MoRR), and by improved IDP profiling and monitoring mechanisms.

Meanwhile, the Afghan authorities, the country's security forces and the international military presence should prioritise efforts to prevent displacement and minimise its effects. Internal displacement also needs to figure prominently in discussions during the Afghan Stakeholders' Conference in May 2012, but at the same time it is crucial that any reintegration strategy for returnees does not divert attention or resources from current protection and humanitarian needs of IDPs.



Source: UNHCR

More maps are available at www.internal-displacement.org

Background

Three decades of armed conflict have taken a devastating toll on the Afghan population, forcing millions to flee within Afghanistan and abroad in numerous waves of displacement, occasionally in parallel with others' return. Three out of four Afghans report having experienced displacement at least once during their lives, of whom over 40 per cent have been internally displaced and 17 per cent have been displaced both internally and to other countries (Oxfam, 2009, p.4).

An estimated five million Afghans were displaced by the 1978 to 1988 armed conflict between the Soviet-supported communist government and nationalist and Islamic insurgencies. The mujahideen civil war between 1992 and 1993 displaced another 200,000, and hundreds of thousands of Pashtuns fled violence caused by Uzbek and Tajik warlords in the north and east in the years that followed. The Taliban's war against the Northern Alliance, fought with the support of Pashtun communities trying to recapture their land, forced another million Afghans into internal displacement. The post-2001 armed conflict between the US-backed Northern Alliance and the Taliban and their supporters, as well as renewed ethnic violence targeting Pashtuns in the north of the country, displaced hundreds of thousands more. More than five million refugees and more than a million internally displaced people (IDPs) are believed to have returned during the period of relative calm after 2002 (BI /TLO, 2010).

Despite a decade of major security and reconstruction assistance, Afghanistan continues to be marred by political fragility and weak rule of law. Rising civilian death tolls – more than 3,000 civilians were killed in 2011 – and increasing levels of displacement reflect the renewed escalation and spread of armed conflict (UNAMA, 2012, p.1). The government is neither able to guarantee security, nor to deliver basic services to the majority of the population (ICG, August 2011, p.i), and its lack of

outreach is evidenced by the rule of local strongmen and Taliban "shadow" governance in many rural areas. Persistent insecurity, chronic poverty and natural disasters have left the population facing immense humanitarian needs. Afghanistan ranks 172 out of 187 countries in the UN's Human Development Index, with over 40 per cent of the population living below the poverty line and almost a third suffering food insecurity. Two-thirds of Afghans have no access to safe water and sanitation facilities, and more than one in six – the majority of them women – have no access to basic health services (OCHA, December 2011, p.11).

Causes of internal displacement since 2004

The armed conflict pitting the Afghan security forces and their international counterparts against the Taliban and other armed opposition groups remains the primary cause of internal displacement. Many Afghans have fled in anticipation of hostilities or in response to threats of violence, while others escape attacks and human rights abuses by the various parties to the conflict.

Military operations and night searches by pro-government forces have resulted in large-scale displacements. US troops and the NATO-led *International Security Assistance Force (ISAF)* have made successful efforts over the past couple of years to minimise civilian casualties and loss of life, but a similar commitment is required to reduce the scale of forced internal displacement (ICOS, 2010; BI /TLO, 2010; TLO /NRC, 2011; AI 2012).

Armed opposition groups are responsible for the majority of civilian casualties and a major cause of forced displacement. They often embed themselves in local communities, and continue to employ the tactics of asymmetric warfare, including suicide attacks, the use of improvised explosive devices, random ambushes and campaigns of intimidation (ICG, June 2011; APC Overview N / NE, 2011; UNGA/UNSC December, 2011; UNAMA, 2012).

Indirect consequences of the conflict, such as the breakdown of law and order, the loss of livelihoods and a lack of access to social services have also reduced the resilience of the civilian population and have figured in people's often-complex decisions to flee their homes (BI /TLO, 2010).

Armed opposition groups' attacks on schools, hospitals and health care facilities, often in violation of international humanitarian law, have disrupted access to essential services, encouraging many to leave and preventing others from returning. Human rights abuses committed by the well-resourced but poorly monitored Afghan Local Police are increasingly recognised as a driver of displacement in many rural areas (TLO /NRC, 2011; APC Overview N/NE, 2011).

Displacements have also been caused by communal and inter-ethnic disputes over access to land and water, such as the recurrent clashes between Kuchi and Hazara groups in the central highlands (AAN, 17 May 2010; IRIN, 13 May 2009, 23 November 2010; AIHRC, 2011).

Displacement figures

According to the National IDP Task Force, which is co-led by the Ministry of Refugees and Repatriation (MoRR) and the UN High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR), 448,000 people remained internally displaced by armed conflict, human rights abuses and other generalised violence as of the end of 2011. The number of conflict-induced IDPs has been rising steadily since 2007, increasing by 27 per cent in 2011 and almost doubling since the end of 2008. More than a quarter – or 117,000 people – fled prior to 2003, and some have been displaced for decades (UNHCR IDP data 2012).

New displacements have recently outnumbered the number of IDPs displaced prior to 2003. An average of 400 new internal displacements a day were recorded between 2006 and 2010 (UN and

ICRC), and 186,000 people were newly displaced by conflict and insecurity during 2011, almost double the figure for 2010 (UNHCR IDP data 2012).

Official IDP figures are widely considered to under-represent the scale of the problem as they exclude those dispersed in urban and semi-urban areas and those displaced to inaccessible rural locations, including large swaths of the conflict-affected southern, eastern and south-eastern regions. Methodologies for collecting and analysing IDP data are not uniform, they do not capture return, secondary displacement or onward migration into exile, and they are often not disaggregated by age or gender. Monitoring is complicated by the fluidity of population movements and difficulties in distinguishing between forced displacement and economic migration (BI /LSE, 2011; BI /TLO, 2010; AI, 2012).

A further 40,000 people remained displaced by natural disasters as of the end of 2011. The majority fled drought and floods, while others were escaping the effects of avalanches, landslides, harsh winter conditions and river bank erosion (IOM, 2012).

Patterns of displacement

The southern, south-eastern, eastern, and western regions of Afghanistan continue to witness the overwhelming majority of internal displacement, but the spread of armed conflict to the previously less-affected northern and central regions has also triggered new displacements in those areas. The number of people fleeing their homes in the north and west of the country more than doubled between 2010 and 2011 (UNHCR IDP data 2010 and 2011). The poorest and most vulnerable Afghans are unable to leave the country or even to leave their homes (BI /TLO 2010 p. 64). Insecurity and the continuing closure of refugee camps in Pakistan reduce cross-border displacement options to the east, as does the deportation

of unregistered Afghan refugees and migrants from Iran to the west (BI /LSE 2011, UNHCR, 2012).

Many IDPs rely on the support of relatives and tribal networks during their displacement (BI / TLO, 2010), while others live in camp-like settings in rural areas. Increasing numbers seek the protection and livelihood opportunities of urban areas, where they live in informal settlements or amid the urban poor.

Displacement to urban areas is generally prompted by a combination of push-factors – the effects of conflict and insecurity – and pull-factors such as employment prospects and food security (WB /UNHCR, 2011; MEI /FRS, 25 January 2011). More than 90 per cent of urban IDPs originate from rural areas, and their displacement is rarely temporary. Urban IDPs have been displaced for an average of six years and at least one in four fled before 2003. Significantly, nine out of ten plan to settle permanently, the vast majority citing the lack of livelihood opportunities in their place of origin (WB /UNHCR, 2011).

Secondary and protracted displacement

The nationwide escalation of the armed conflict and the absence of livelihood opportunities and basic services such as education and health care have prevented IDPs from returning, and forced many into secondary or even tertiary displacement. These same factors have also slowed recent returns of refugees and prevented an estimated 43 per cent from reintegrating into their home communities. A quarter of urban IDPs are thought to be returning refugees forced into secondary displacement (AIHRC, 2011; UNHCR, 28 October 2011; WB / UNHCR, 2011). As a result, many IDPs live in protracted displacement, often with only limited prospects of achieving a durable solution (APC, 2011).

Protection concerns

Many IDPs continue to face threats to their physical security and integrity while in displacement

and upon their return. They may live amid parties to the conflict in areas of contested control, where they face the risk of extortion or harassment by armed opposition groups, members of the Afghan security forces and recently also the Afghan Local Police. Male IDPs and returnees face the additional risk of forced recruitment or being accused of association with one party to the conflict or the other.

The prevalence of mines, improvised explosive devices, and explosive remnants of war (ERW) constitutes a major threat to IDPs trying to settle in unfamiliar places and those returning to former combat areas. Unexploded ordnance also restricts access to shelter, water and land for grazing and cultivation, and it hampers the restoration of essential infrastructure.

Food security is a major challenge for both IDPs and returnees. Insecurity, damaged or occupied property and mine /ERW contamination restrict the ability of returnees to re-establish their livelihoods, while IDPs often lack the contacts or skills necessary to enter the labour market in their places of refuge.

Many are also unable to meet their basic needs in terms of water, shelter and health care. Precarious living conditions and harsh winter weather leave many vulnerable to diseases such as pneumonia, dysentery and diarrhoea - a situation made worse in conflict areas by insecurity and the forced closure of hospitals and clinics.

IDPs with specific protection needs

Female IDPs and returnees are among the most vulnerable groups as a result of their lack of rights and restricted autonomy. Their capacity to cope during displacement is particularly challenged by the custom of *purdah* or seclusion, which severely hampers their access to resources, employment, health care, education and the justice system (APC, February 2011; OCHA, December 2011). They also risk gender-based

violence or being forced into early marriage (AI, 2012; OCHA, April 2011).

Displacement deprives individuals of their protective communities and family structures. Children face the risk of forced recruitment, sexual violence, child labour and trafficking, and 85 per cent of casualties caused by mines and ERW are under 18 (Watchlist, 2010; SRS-G-CAC, 2010; OCHA, December 2011). The disabled and older people are also particularly vulnerable to protection risks such as seclusion, discrimination and limited livelihood opportunities.

In a country in which only 42 per cent of children in the general population attend primary school (OCHA, December 2011), prevailing insecurity and the forced closure of many schools prevent many IDPs and returnees from accessing education. In relatively secure areas other obstacles exist, such as long distances to travel to school, lack of documentation, and discrimination on the part of education officials (AI, 2012; Watchlist, 2010).

Urban IDPs

Rapid urbanisation has strained the capacity of urban areas to accommodate the needs of an increasing influx of IDPs. A recent World Bank-UNHCR study revealed that urban IDPs are more vulnerable and deprived than the non-displaced urban poor. Their lack of appropriate skills for the urban labour market and lower literacy rates limit their chances of finding work and they are five times more likely to be food insecure (WB / UNHCR, 2011).

Urban IDPs also have less access to adequate housing (WB / UNHCR, 2011). Some 85 per cent do not hold title deeds, and many are forced to live in substandard conditions in informal settlements. Some 60 per cent live in tents, temporary shelters or shacks, with at least 30,000 living in as many as 40 informal sites in Kabul. Others face the constant threat of eviction (WB / UNHCR, 2011; MEI / FRS, 25 January 2011). Informal settlements

rarely offer adequate protection from the elements – at least 22 internally displaced children living in Kabul's slums died of exposure during the 2011-2012 winter (NYT, 3 February 2012). Only a third of urban IDPs have access to electricity, adequate water supplies and sanitation facilities, and cramped living conditions and poor hygiene have left many vulnerable to illness (WB / UNHCR, 2011; AI, 2012).

Durable solutions and settlement options

Return

Information on return movements and their sustainability is limited, but some IDPs have reportedly been able to go back safely to their home areas where they found their property and livelihoods intact. Others have been able to overcome initial challenges and have made some progress towards recovery.

That said, persistent insecurity in many parts of the country, difficulties in re-establishing livelihoods and restricted access to basic services have limited many IDPs' ability to return sustainably to their places of origin. Natural disasters have also affected many return areas, one example being the decade of recurring slow-onset drought in the northern and western regions. In addition, the prospect of a durable solution tends to decrease the longer the period of displacement, due in part to weakening support networks and the heightened risk that IDPs' property will have been occupied in their absence.

Landlessness and the challenges in reclaiming land and property pose significant obstacles for both IDPs and refugees trying to return. Neither the formal judicial system, nor traditional conflict-resolution mechanisms provide sufficient remedy for property claims, and they rarely uphold women's property and inheritance rights (MEI / FRS 25 January and 9 February 2011). A govern-

ment-administered land allocation scheme has been marred by corruption and mismanagement and has failed to provide for the majority of landless IDPs and returnees. Eligibility is limited and the land available is often located far from income sources or public services (NRC, 2009; BI /TLO, 2010; MEI /FRS, 9 February 2011; AI, 2012).

Local integration and settlement elsewhere

IDPs wishing to integrate locally or settle elsewhere also face many obstacles, and their strategies to overcome them have varied significantly. Many seek the support of extended families, but often at the price of straining their meagre coping strategies. Tensions have also arisen with local communities over competition for limited resources. The difficulty in obtaining identity documents or *tazkera* prevents IDPs from accessing services and job opportunities, and from participating in civil and political affairs (AI, 2012).

The government's focus on return as its preferred settlement option is a substantial barrier to local integration and does not sufficiently address the immediate or long-term needs of IDPs seeking other settlement options. There is reluctance to create potential pull factors through the provision of humanitarian assistance and a perceived fear that facilitating local integration will slow the rate of returns (BI /TLO, 2010).

National response

The Afghan government has been unable to provide its citizens with sufficient protection, to prevent displacement or to minimise its adverse effects (BI /TLO, 2011; BI /LSE, 2011). It is estimated that the government exercises effective control over less than half of the country and institutions remain weak, corrupt, or ineffective. MoRR and the sub-ministerial Afghanistan Natural Disaster Management Authority are mandated to deal with IDP-related issues, but neither have the institutional capacity, resources or political stature

to respond effectively (BI/ TLO, 2010; BI /LSE, 2011; AIHRC, 2011). Indeed, many government officials deny that internal displacement is a problem and describe IDPs as economic migrants (IRIN, 3 May 2010; AI, 2012).

In Afghanistan's national development strategy for 2008 to 2013, the government recognises its responsibility to protect IDPs (GoA 2008), but both policy and practice tend to promote return as the primary settlement option, often neglecting to address the necessary conditions for IDPs to integrate locally or settle elsewhere in the country.

Afghan national authorities have yet to develop a comprehensive legal framework for IDPs or to formally adopt a policy to protect their human rights (BI /LSE, 2011; BI /NRC, November 2010). There are, however, recent indications of a keen government interest in developing a national IDP policy with the assistance of the UN, NGOs and other stakeholders (National IDP TF, 14 March 2012).

Given that internal displacement is likely at least to continue, if not get worse, such a policy would be a welcome and timely initiative. It should also focus on the need to mainstream IDPs within national development programmes and reflect the fact that the vast majority of IDPs living in urban areas would prefer to reintegrate locally. It should, therefore, include a strategy to address issues such as land and housing needs, security of tenure, documentation and access to basic services (WB /UNHCR, 2011; BI, 2011; RI, 2011; MEI /FRS, 25 January 2011).

International response

Despite extensive international commitment over the past decade, Afghanistan's transition towards peace and stability remains far from complete. Domestic and international support for foreign military engagement is dwindling, however, and there have been widespread calls for the country

to assume responsibility for its own security. US forces taking part in Operation Enduring Freedom have begun a gradual withdrawal, and ISAF is scheduled to complete its handover of security responsibility by 2014 (UN News, 12 October 2011). Afghanistan, meanwhile, continues to rely heavily on international funding, which in 2010 accounted for 85 per cent of public expenditure (OCHA, December 2011). President Hamid Karzai has repeatedly appealed for the continued commitment of the international community beyond 2014 (BBC News, 5 December 2011).

The humanitarian response targeting IDPs is coordinated through the cluster system and led by the National IDP Task Force. Jointly chaired by MoRR and UNHCR, the Task Force's aims include strengthening the government's capacity and leadership of the IDP response, and improving the profiling and monitoring of IDPs via the management and standardisation of data collection among the provincial Departments of Refugee and Repatriation (DoRRs) (National IDP TF 2011 Work Plan). Task force members have also pledged their support for the development of a national IDP policy (National IDP TF, 14 March 2012).

The 2012 Consolidated Appeal for Afghanistan (CAP) is seeking \$437 million for 146 projects across eight clusters and one sub-cluster working group. Its targets include 600,000 conflict-induced IDPs and 70,000 affected by natural disasters (OCHA, December 2011). Additional aid is channelled through other mechanisms, including bilateral funding.

Despite Afghanistan's history of displacement, the sheer scale of the current and growing crisis has caught most parties involved unprepared and they have failed to meet the needs of the country's IDPs (TLO /NRC, 2011). Underfunding, the ineffectiveness of aid provided, differing donor priorities and the absence of reliable and timely information about displacement in conflict zones have hampered the humanitarian response. Only

58 per cent of the 2011 CAP had been funded by January 2012 (OCHA, December 2011).

The vast majority of IDPs and returnees, meanwhile, remain beyond the reach of humanitarian response. Access has been severely restricted by insecurity, the country's mountainous geography and severe climate, and poor infrastructure. UN agencies have direct access to only about half of the country (OCHA, December 2011) and in 2011 the Afghanistan NGO Safety Office reported a 20 per cent increase in attacks against humanitarian workers (ANSO, 2012). Insecurity has forced many organisations to reduce the scope of their activities or operate through local partners. Given the regular blurring of humanitarian activities with political and military agendas, targeted advocacy efforts to secure access have stressed the need to ensure principled humanitarian action and to strengthen independent coordination by the UN.

The Afghan Stakeholders Conference scheduled for May 2012 will seek to address the issue of refugees and returnees and the implementation of the government-adopted "Solutions Strategy" aimed, among other things, at improving conditions in return areas (IRIN, 27 February 2012). Given the complex and inter-related causes of forced displacement and the serious obstacles facing both internally displaced and exiled populations in achieving a durable solution, it is essential that the Afghan government and international community adopt a holistic national displacement strategy which includes IDPs as well as refugees. It is also crucial that any reintegration strategy for refugees adopted not divert attention or resources from the current protection and humanitarian needs of IDPs.

Note: This is a summary of IDMC's internal displacement profile on Afghanistan. The full profile is available online [here](#).

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About the Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre

The Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre (IDMC) was established by the Norwegian Refugee Council in 1998, upon the request of the United Nations, to set up a global database on internal displacement. A decade later, IDMC remains the leading source of information and analysis on internal displacement caused by conflict and violence worldwide.

IDMC aims to support better international and national responses to situations of internal displacement and respect for the rights of internally displaced people (IDPs), who are often among the world's most vulnerable people. It also aims to promote durable solutions for IDPs, through return, local integration or settlement elsewhere in the country.

IDMC's main activities include:

- Monitoring and reporting on internal displacement caused by conflict, generalised violence and violations of human rights;
- Researching, analysing and advocating for the rights of IDPs;
- Training and strengthening capacities on the protection of IDPs;
- Contributing to the development of standards and guidance on protecting and assisting IDPs.

For more information, visit the Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre website and the database at www.internal-displacement.org

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